



Shiming Wu

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Education

The University of British Columbia, Vancouver, Canada

PhD in Economics

2020 - 2026 (expected)

Master of Science in Business Administration in Finance

2018 - 2020

Nankai University, Tianjin, China

Bachelor of Economics in Finance

2012 - 2015

Fields

Insurance, Industrial Organization, Environmental Economics, Financial Economics, Machine Learning

References

Paul Schrimpf

Advisor

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Gorkem Bostanci

Advisor

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Katherine Wagner

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David Green

david.green@ubc.ca

Prof. Gorkem Bostanci and Prof. Katherine Wagner have requested that our department submit letters for them. Please email econ.grad@ubc.ca for reference letters. Thanks.

Research Grants, Awards, and Fellowships

CIDER Small Grants in Innovative Data (C\$26,000)

2023 – 2024

Sir Quo-Wei Lee Fellowship from St. John's College

2024 - 2026

Harnan A.N. Singh Scholarship in Economics

2022

President's Academic Excellence Initiative PhD Award

2020 – 2026

Faculty of Arts Graduate Fellowship

2020 – 2025

International Student Tuition Award

2018 – 2026

Merit Student and Scholarships from Nankai University

2012 - 2015

Job Market Paper

What Constrains Insolvency in Property Insurance?

Market Discipline, Capital Regulation, and Catastrophe Exposure

- This paper disentangles the roles of capital regulation and credit ratings in mitigating insolvency risk in the U.S. property insurance market. I first investigate the mechanism through which capital requirements affect the insurance market. Using reduced-form evidence and an instrumental variable approach that exploits a 2017 policy change as a quasi-experiment, I find that a \$1 million increase in required capital leads insurers to hold \$3.34 million more in capital and to raise insurance prices by 0.218 percentage points. These results reveal a direct trade-off between financial stability and consumer affordability. To further explore the underlying mechanisms, I develop a structural model in which insurers make capital

and pricing decisions in a competitive market with limited liability and exposure to catastrophic risks. Counterfactual analyses show that tightening capital requirements improves solvency but raises prices. In the absence of capital regulation, the model predicts that the insolvency rate would increase by 0.09 percentage points, while insurance prices would decline by about 5.1%, accompanied by greater risk-taking and market concentration. A third counterfactual scenario examines a market without capital regulation but with high credit rating salience. When consumers place greater emphasis on credit ratings, the insolvency rate decreases; however, intensified price competition reduces profitability and increases market concentration. Overall, the findings underscore that capital regulation remains crucial for sustaining market stability, as heightened rating salience alone cannot fully substitute for its stabilizing effects.

- MLE to estimate return distribution and losses distributions
- BLP type supply estimation to estimate random shocks of insolvency
- Random forest to impute missing credit rating
- Generalized additive model (GAM) to estimate capital and credit rating functions
- I built a Linux workstation to run estimation

Working Papers

Transformation of College to University and Impacts on Labor Market Outcomes and Training Participation under Employment Insurance

- This paper studies the impacts of different types of post-secondary education on education and labor market outcomes, with a particular focus on training participation during unemployment under Canada’s Employment Insurance (EI) system. I first use variations of distances to institutions and exogenous variations of colleges that upgraded into universities to investigate the value added to university education. Then I separately estimate the impacts of the transformed universities and traditional colleges and universities. I compare results from OLS and IV regressions. To address treatment heterogeneity, I adapt the locally linear specification from Mountjoy (2022). Results suggest that the difference between university and college graduates is marginal. However, university entry improves labor market outcomes, such as employment and earnings, compared with cohorts without post-secondary education. Graduates from transformed universities obtain a higher probability of being employed and higher earnings compared with people without post-secondary education. Nonetheless, transformed university graduates may have worse performance in the labor market compared with graduates from colleges or traditional universities. In addition, transformed university graduates are more likely to register for EI-supported training programs during unemployment, compared with graduates from colleges, traditional universities, and individuals without post-secondary education, highlighting an important interaction between higher education pathways and training incentives embedded in the EI system.

A Reinforcement Learning Approach to Dynamic Capital Regulation in Property Insurance

- Regulators in the U.S. property insurance market face a critical challenge: transitioning from static, formula-based capital requirements to dynamic, model-based regimes. While dynamic regulation offers the potential to improve social welfare and market resilience, it suffers from two major barriers: computational intractability under profound uncertainty and a lack of interpretability required for regulatory oversight. In this paper, I propose a novel framework for outcome-based regulatory design. I develop a “Learn-Verify-Explain” methodology that utilizes Deep Reinforcement Learning to discover optimal dynamic capital strategies. Unlike traditional black-box approaches, my framework integrates Formal Verification to mathematically guarantee compliance with safety constraints and Decision Tree Extraction to distill complex policies into transparent, implementable rules. Empirical results demonstrate that this hybrid approach outperforms traditional static benchmarks, increasing social welfare by approximately 35%

while reducing insolvency rates to zero. Crucially, the distilled policy reveals a risk-sensitive stabilization strategy: the agent learns to prioritize market efficiency through deregulation during stable periods, while imposing immediate corrective tightening upon detecting early signs of distress. This study provides an experiment of “AI-in-the-loop” financial regulation.

The Impacts of Health Insurance Mandates on the Labour Market and Health, Evidence from ACA

- This paper studies how employer mandates and health insurance affect labor market outcomes and health. I use staggered difference-in-differences research design and variations in the Affordable Care Act to learn how employer mandate affects labor market outcomes. I use doubly robust difference-in-differences in my main specifications to reduce selection bias. Results in the full sample suggest that the employer mandates in the Affordable Care Act increased hourly wages and did not have significant impacts on employment and part-time employment. Employer mandates stimulate a larger increase in employer-sponsored health insurance coverage rates among low-income workers. However, low-income workers are more vulnerable to involuntary part-time employment if employers reduce work hours to circumvent employer mandates. Firms prefer to reduce work hours to circumvent employer mandates instead of firing workers. Using doubly robust estimators and staggered difference-in-differences research design, I find evidence that providing health insurance improves workers’ health. The employer mandate may increase productivity by improving workers’ health status. Still, it may widen income inequality in the long run because low-income workers are more vulnerable to work hours losses.

Work in Progress

Mitigating the Trade-off: How Natural Catastrophe Adaptation Can Reconcile Insurer Solvency and Affordability

- Stringent capital regulation in property insurance markets creates a tension between insurer solvency and affordability. This paper demonstrates that adaptation to natural catastrophes can mitigate this trade-off. I develop and estimate a model of the property insurance market with interdependent loss structures, competition, and capital regulation. My counterfactual analysis shows that adaptation measures, by reducing the correlation of losses, would decrease the market insolvency rate and lower market concentration. Furthermore, I find a net positive impact on social welfare when the costs of insurer insolvency are repurposed to subsidize adaptation. My results indicate that policy should focus on incentivizing adaptation as a key tool for maintaining sustainable insurance markets.

From Monoculture to Market: The Economics of Plant Biodiversity and Consumer Welfare

- This paper investigates the complex relationship between industrial agriculture, plant biodiversity, and economic welfare. While industrial agriculture has been credited with increasing food production, it has also been linked to a significant decline in agrobiodiversity. This research disentangles two opposing economic forces: the homogenizing effect of industrial agriculture’s focus on a few high-yield, storable crops, and the potential for market competition to foster product variety. I develop and estimate a structural model of demand and supply for fresh produce, employing a random coefficients logit model (BLP) to capture heterogeneous consumer preferences for a wide range of crop attributes, including variety. On the supply side, I model farmers’ and food companies’ decisions to offer different cultivars, considering the influence of production costs, market structure, and agricultural policies. Using detailed market-level data, I quantify the welfare effects of changes in plant biodiversity on consumers and producers. Furthermore, I extend the traditional welfare analysis to incorporate the non-market value of agrobiodiversity as a source of resilience to climate shocks. My findings aim to provide a more complete picture of the true social costs and benefits of industrial agriculture and to inform policies that promote a more diverse and sustainable food system.

Teaching

ECON 502 Macroeconomics, teaching TA (UBC)
ECON 490 Seminar in Applied Economics, TA (UBC)
ECON 370 Benefit-Cost Analysis and the Economics of Project Evaluation, TA (UBC)
ECON 356 Introduction to International Finance, TA (UBC)
ECON 255 Understanding Globalization, teaching TA (UBC)
ECON 102 Principles of Macroeconomics, teaching TA (UBC)
ECON 101 Principles of Microeconomics, teaching TA (UBC)

Conferences

2024: 19th CIREQ PhD Students' Conference
2022: NBER Insurance Working Group Meeting

Employment

Teaching assistant at University of British Columbia	2021 - present, Vancouver, Canada
Research assistant at University of British Columbia	2019 - 2024, Vancouver, Canada
Tutor and teaching assistant at Yingde Inspiration Education	2017 - 2018, Yingde, China
Auditor at KPMG	2015 - 2016, Beijing, China

Other Information

Computer Skills	R, Julia, Stata, Matlab, SPSS, Python, L ^A T _E X
Data Science	Machine learning, Causal inference, Structural estimation
Languages	English (fluent), Mandarin (native), Cantonese (native), French (learning)
Certificates	Passed CFA Level II Exam
Datasets	Bloomberg, Capital IQ
Gender	Female